

Allow and prohibit

Teaching guide

Explain permission and restrictions clearly.

Understand the distinction

Allow commonly takes a person plus to + verb: They allow visitors to take photos. Without a named person, use an -ing form: They allow photography / taking photos. The passive is be allowed to.

Prohibit commonly takes an activity or person + from + -ing: The rules prohibit parking here; they prohibit visitors from entering. Must not expresses a prohibition. Do not have to expresses lack of obligation, which is different.

Compare the patterns

PERMISSION

Visitors are allowed to take photos.

Taking photos is permitted.

PROHIBITION

Parking here is prohibited.

Parking here is not permitted.

NO OBLIGATION

You do not have to print the ticket.

Printing is optional, not forbidden.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete: They allow us ___ leave early.

2. Complete: The rule prohibits staff from ___ here. (smoke)

3. Does You do not have to wait mean waiting is forbidden?

Use it in your own life

Write one permission and one restriction for a shared space.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. to

Use allow someone to do something.

2. smoking

Use from + -ing.

3. No. Waiting is not required.

Use must not wait if it is prohibited.

One possible response

You may use the kitchen. You must not leave the door unlocked.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-13.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write one permission and one restriction for a shared space.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.